

Which of the following statements about race is most consistent with the social constructionist perspective? In society, race is:

- ☐ A. determined by genes. [3%]
- ✓ ☒ B. defined and maintained through social interactions. [71%]
- ☐ C. an achieved status. [2%]
- ☐ D. a social category used to maintain dynamic equilibrium. [22%]

Correct

71% answered correctly

Explanation:

Major theoretical approaches to sociology			
Theory	Description	Perspective	Theorists
Functionalism	- Society = an organism - Each part of society works to maintain dynamic equilibrium (homeostasis)	Macro	Émile Durkheim, Talcott Parsons
Conflict	- Society = struggle for limited resources - Inequality based on social class	Macro	Karl Marx, Max Weber
Social constructionism	- Social actors define what is real - Knowledge about world based on interactions	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)
Symbolic interactionism	- Meaning & value attached to symbols - Individual interactions based on these symbols	Micro	Charles Cooley, George Herbert Mead
Rational choice/social exchange	Individual behaviors & interactions attempt to maximize personal gain & minimize personal cost	Micro	(Not critical for exam)
Feminist	Examines gender inequality in society	Macro or micro	(Not critical for exam)

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Social constructionism is a sociological theory suggesting that "reality" is created through social interactions, resulting in **agreed-upon, shared meanings**. Objects (eg, money), behaviors (eg, handshaking), and categories (eg, race) have meaning only because individuals in society have agreed on that meaning, making them **social constructs**.

Racial categories are considered social constructs because they have no clear biological basis and are largely defined by certain physical traits (eg, skin color). Racial categories also vary by society: an individual with one black parent may be considered black in the United States but not in another country.

A definition of race that is maintained through social interactions is *most consistent* with the social constructionist perspective.

(Choice A) There are no clear genetic markers that characteristically define any racial category. Also, the social constructionist perspective is concerned with the *social* (not biological) basis of race.

(Choice C) Social status (one's rank relative to others in society) can be achieved (attained) or ascribed (assigned based on personal characteristics such as race or class). Race is an ascribed (not an achieved) status.

(Choice D) From the functionalist perspective, which asserts that various parts of society work together to maintain dynamic equilibrium (ie, societal balance), race might be considered a social category that helps to maintain dynamic equilibrium, but this is not consistent with the social constructionist perspective.

Educational objective:

Social constructionism is a theory suggesting that social interactions establish "reality" through the creation of social constructs (eg, race), which have meaning only because individuals in society have agreed on that meaning.

Time spent:0 sec
Subject:
Behavioral Sciences

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System:
Identity and Social Interaction